

Nasopharyngeal (Inflammatory) Polyps

What are they?

Nasopharyngeal polyps are **benign (non-cancerous) growths** of inflamed tissue that develop in the middle ear, the Eustachian tube, or the back of the throat behind the nose (nasopharynx). They are most common in **young cats** and occasionally occur in dogs. The cause is not fully understood; chronic inflammation or a past upper respiratory infection may play a role.

Signs

Depending on where the polyp grows:

- Noisy or labored breathing; snoring; nasal congestion
- Chronic sneezing or nasal discharge
- **Head tilt**, ear scratching, head shaking, ear discharge (middle ear)
- Trouble swallowing or voice change
- Sometimes Horner's syndrome (small pupil, droopy eyelid)

Diagnosis

- Physical and ear exam — sometimes the mass is visible behind the soft palate or through the eardrum
- **Sedated exam** of the mouth and throat
- **CT** (or MRI) to see the full extent, especially into the middle ear

- Occasionally a biopsy to confirm the diagnosis

Treatment

The main treatment is **surgical removal**:

- **Traction/avulsion** — gently pulling the polyp free, usually through the mouth or ear canal. Less invasive, but more likely to grow back, especially if the polyp starts in the middle ear.
- **Ventral bulla osteotomy (VBO)** — surgery that opens the middle ear (bulla) to remove the polyp at its root. Lower recurrence; often recommended for middle-ear polyps.

A short course of anti-inflammatory medication (such as a steroid) after removal may reduce regrowth.

After surgery

Temporary Horner's syndrome or a head tilt can occur after middle-ear surgery and usually improves over weeks.

Prognosis

Most pets do **very well**; breathing and ear signs improve quickly. Polyps can come back — more often after traction than after VBO. Watch for return of snoring, head shaking or ear discharge, and keep your recheck appointment.